Lesson 4 — One Small Thing, Many Times

Part 4 of 12: Grammar — the present perfect

Level: A2+ (fourth step)

About 50 minutes · this part carries a sheet

Come back to: the past continuous

Lesson 3 taught it. Two lines to remind you:

I / HE / SHE / IT	WAS WORKING
you / we / they	were working

when + past simple, while + past continuous.

New this time: two more jobs it does.

1. Two long actions at the same time. Put while in front of one of them:

   While* Lina was building the website, her uncle was working* in the shop.

2. A picture at one moment in the past, often with still:

   At eleven o'clock she was still working.

Quick practice. Put the verb in the past continuous:

1. While Lina _____ (build) the website, her uncle _____ (work) in the shop.
2. At midnight she _____ (still / study).
3. They _____ (wait) for the connection when it came back.

We use the present perfect when the past still touches now: She has built a website — and the website is there today.

3.1 How we make it

have / has + the past participle

PERSON	PRESENT PERFECT
I / you / we / they	have finished
he / she / it	has finished

The past participle of a regular verb is the -ed form you already know. The common irregular ones must be learned:

NOW	PAST PARTICIPLE
be	been
do	done
see	seen
take	taken
build	built
lose	lost
sell	sold
meet	met
pay	paid
finish	finished (regular)
learn	learned (regular)
decide	decided (regular)

3.2 What we use it for

Experience, at any time in your life: She has never met her teacher.

Something that started in the past and is still true: He has sold the same things for twenty years.

A past action with a result now: She has lost her work many times, so now she saves every few minutes.

With for and since: for + a length of time (for two years), since + a point in time (since March).

3.4 Present perfect or past simple?

PAST SIMPLE — FINISHED TIME	PRESENT PERFECT — UNFINISHED, OR THE RESULT NOW
In March, she built a website.	Since March, the shop has had new customers.
She published it on a free service.	She has not finished the course yet.
It took her eleven days.	He has sold the same things for twenty years.

The rule to remember: if the sentence says when it happened and that time is over (in March, two years ago, yesterday), use the past simple. If it says for, since, yet, already, ever or never, use the present perfect.

3.5 Negative and question

	FORM	EXAMPLE
Negative	have not / has not + participle	He has not learned to use a computer.
Question	Have / Has + person + participle	Has she finished the course?

3.6 Grammar practice

A. Put the verb in the present perfect:

1. Lina _____ (study) at her college for three years.
2. She _____ (never / meet) her teacher.
3. The shop _____ (have) customers from other cities since March.
4. She _____ (not finish) the course yet.
5. He _____ (already / ask) for two new pages.
6. They _____ (never / see) the shop.

B. Past simple or present perfect?

1. In March, she (built / has built) a website.
2. Since March, the shop (had / has had) new customers.
3. She (published / has published) it on a free service.
4. She (did not finish / has not finished) the course yet.
5. Her uncle (sold / has sold) the same things for twenty years.

C. Write for or since:

1. ____ three years
2. ____ March
3. ____ twenty years
4. ____ she was a child